Theme 1: Retail Therapy

A Fair Exchange (Reading: skimming)

Lesson 1-1
Book pages 1-3

💡 **Big idea:** Trade has changed the course of history. The **Omanis** have always been great traders: first **frankincense**, silk and spices on **dhows**, and today **oil** on supertankers. We practise **skimming** to find the gist (main idea) of a text.

🎯 **I will learn:**

- Skim a text quickly to find the main idea
- Match headings to paragraphs using topic sentences
- Find words with similar meanings in a text
- Talk about trading and exchanging things

📖 Key words

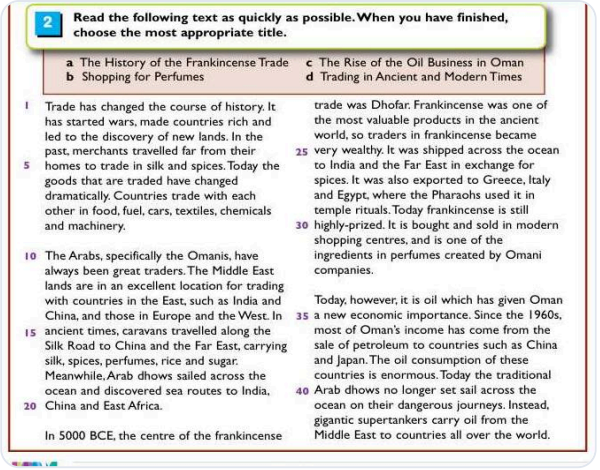
trade تجارة	**merchant** تاجر	**frankincense** اللبان	**export** يُصدِّر
ritual طقس / شعيرة	**location** موقع	**enormous** ضخم	**dramatically** بشكل كبير ومفاجئ
skimming القراءة السريعة لفهم الفكرة العامة	**retail therapy** التسوق لتحسين المزاج		

The text: trading past and present

- Merchants travelled far to trade in silk and spices
- Oman's location is excellent for trading between East and West
- In 5000 BCE the centre of the frankincense trade was Dhofar
- Frankincense was exported to India, Greece, Italy and Egypt
- Since the 1960s most of Oman's income has come from oil
- Dhows (wood, wind) were replaced by supertankers (steel, engines)

Top tip: dealing with a new text

- Skim first to find the **gist** before reading in detail
- Use headings, pictures and charts to find key information
- The **topic sentence** gives the main idea of each paragraph



2 Read the following text as quickly as possible. When you have finished, choose the most appropriate title.

a The History of the Frankincense Trade
b Shopping for Perfumes
c The Rise of the Oil Business in Oman
d Trading in Ancient and Modern Times

Trade has changed the course of history. It has started wars, made countries rich and led to the discovery of new lands. In the past, merchants travelled far from their homes to trade in silk and spices. Today the goods that are traded have changed dramatically. Countries trade with each other in food, fuel, cars, textiles, chemicals and machinery.

The Arabs, specifically the Omanis, have always been great traders. The Middle East lands are in an excellent location for trading with countries in the East, such as India and China, and those in Europe and the West. In ancient times, caravans travelled along the Silk Road to China and the Far East, carrying silk, spices, perfumes, rice and sugar. Meanwhile, Arab dhows sailed across the ocean and discovered sea routes to India, China and East Africa.

In 5000 BCE, the centre of the frankincense trade was Dhofar. Frankincense was one of the most valuable products in the ancient world, so traders in frankincense became very wealthy. It was shipped across the ocean to India and the Far East in exchange for spices. It was also exported to Greece, Italy and Egypt, where the Pharaohs used it in temple rituals. Today frankincense is still highly-prized. It is bought and sold in modern shopping centres, and is one of the ingredients in perfumes created by Omani companies.

Today, however, it is oil which has given Oman a new economic importance. Since the 1960s, most of Oman's income has come from the sale of petroleum to countries such as China and Japan. The oil consumption of these countries is enormous. Today the traditional Arab dhows no longer set sail across the ocean on their dangerous journeys. Instead, gigantic supertankers carry oil from the Middle East to countries all over the world.

Reading text: trade in ancient and modern times (p.2)

✏️ Examples

Which title is best for the text?

Answer: Trading in Ancient and Modern Times

Find a word in paragraph 4 meaning 'very big'.

Answer: enormous

⭐ Remember

- When you skim, don't read every word. Read the first sentence of each paragraph.

⚠️ Watch out

- ✗ Reading every word slowly when the task says 'as quickly as possible'
  ✓ Skim for the main idea

🧩 **Activity:** Choose a personal item (e.g. your watch) and 'trade' it with a partner using: What will you give me for my watch? / That's a fair deal!

✅ Check yourself

1. Where was the centre of the frankincense trade?
2. What gave Oman new economic importance?
3. What does 'export' mean?
4. What is skimming?

Answers: (1) Dhofar ، (2) oil ، (3) sell to another country ، (4) reading quickly for the main idea